Case Study: Inappropriate Use of Surveys

Cambridge Analytica and Facebook Data Harvesting (2018)

The **Cambridge Analytica scandal** remains one of the most prominent cases of inappropriate data collection and use. In 2018, Cambridge Analytica obtained data from millions of Facebook users through a seemingly harmless personality quiz app titled *This Is Your Digital Life*. While only around 320,000 users consented to take the quiz, Facebook's API policies at the time allowed access to the data of their friends, resulting in the harvesting of up to 87 million profiles without proper consent (Confessore, 2018; Schneble *et al.*, 2018). This data was later used to create psychographic profiles for targeted political advertising, influencing voting behaviours during the 2016 US presidential election and the UK Brexit referendum. The case highlighted how surveys can be exploited for political and financial gain while misleading participants about the purpose of data collection.

A similar incident occurred in 2018 when the quiz platform **NameTests** exposed personal data of up to 120 million users through seemingly innocent Facebook quizzes such as "Which Disney Princess Are You?" Due to a security flaw, sensitive information, such as names, birthdays, and friend lists, was accessible to third parties without adequate safeguards (Statt, 2018). Another case involved the **myPersonality** app, which collected Facebook profile data for academic research but later distributed datasets to researchers and private companies without proper anonymisation or user consent, resulting in a permanent ban by Facebook (Weinberger, 2018).

From an **ethical** perspective, these cases represent significant breaches of informed consent and privacy, violating the principle of transparency in research (Schneble *et al.*, 2018). **Socially**, they eroded public trust in online platforms and surveys, sparking widespread

concern about behavioural manipulation and the exploitation of personal data. The **legal** repercussions were considerable, with Facebook fined £500,000 by the UK Information Commissioner's Office and $5 billion by the US Federal Trade Commission for failing to protect user data (Confessore, 2018). Under the **EU General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR)**, such practices now require explicit consent and robust data protection measures. From a **professional** standpoint, these incidents demonstrated a disregard for codes of ethics within marketing research, where practices such as "sugging" (selling under the guise of surveying) are strictly prohibited. These cases underscore the necessity for ethical integrity, legal compliance, and accountability in professional research practices.

References

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